

warrior-clans with regional power bases. In the 12th-century Gempei Wars, the Minamoto and Taira clans fought, the Minamoto emerging as military rulers of Japan – the shoguns.

In this period, the samurai were primarily mounted bowmen; the art of Japanese sword-making only evolved in the late middle ages. Samurai warfare was highly stylized: battles opened with archery duels between notable warriors, and defeat led to ritual suicide (*hara-kiri*). Nevertheless, when Kublai Khan tried to invade Japan by sea, in 1274 and 1281, he found them to be formidable foes: the Mongols were repulsed, albeit with help from the bad weather that wrecked the invasion fleets.



◀ A SAMURAI RITUAL BEHEADING

It was the custom in medieval Japan for a samurai killed in combat to be beheaded by his enemies. The severed head was then returned to his relatives, mounted on a spiked board.

“They come with the swiftness of lightning, ravaging and slaughtering, striking everyone with terror and with incomparable horror”

ENGLISH MONK MATTHEW PARIS, DESCRIBING THE MONGOLS, c.1250



◀ THE BATTLE OF AIN JALUT

One of the very few defeats suffered by the Mongols came at Ain Jalut, in Palestine, in 1260. The steppe horsemen were beaten by the army of Mamluk Egypt, which fought in a not dissimilar style.

KEY EVENTS

10TH–15TH CENTURY

- **10th century** The samurai are first mentioned, as the Japanese emperor's guards.
- **11th century** In China, gunpowder is first used in warfare.
- **1132** The Song rulers of southern China establish a permanent navy.
- **1180–85** The Gempei Wars between samurai clans lead to the establishment of the Minamoto shogunate in Japan.
- **1241** At the battles of Liegnitz, in Poland, and Mohi, in Hungary, Mongol horsemen prove their military superiority to forces of European knights.
- **1385–1405** Timur carries out campaigns of conquest across much of Asia.
- **1474** Ming China begins the reconstruction of the Great Wall as a barrier against steppe horsemen.